

Collective Intelligence — Module 01: Systems —

Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on teams as nested systems, boundary management, and multi-scale organization.

1. What makes a group of people a "team" rather than just a "group"? Define the transition using the Markov blanket concept.
2. How does boundary permeability affect team performance? When should a team boundary be more closed, and when should it be more open?
3. Pixar's Braintrust deliberately opens team boundaries for critique but preserves team autonomy on decisions. Why is this separation critical? What would go wrong if Braintrust feedback were mandatory?
4. In what ways do remote/distributed teams have different boundary dynamics than co-located teams? What boundary management is easier or harder?
5. How does multi-scale organization (individuals → teams → departments → organization) create emergent capabilities? Provide a specific example where the whole is greater than the sum of its parts.
6. A team with very high coherence might be mistaken for a team experiencing groupthink. How would you distinguish healthy coherence from pathological conformity?
7. When a new member joins an established team, what happens to the team's Markov blanket? How does onboarding serve as a boundary-management process?
8. Compare the boundary dynamics of a permanent team (e.g., a standing product team) versus a temporary team (e.g., a project task force). How do boundary formation and dissolution affect team functioning?

9. How do physical co-location and shared rituals (team lunches, daily standups) contribute to forming and maintaining the team's Markov blanket?
10. Identify the formal and informal boundaries of a team you belong to. Who is clearly "inside"? Who is ambiguously positioned? What determines membership?
11. Rate your team's coherence on the five dimensions (shared model, boundary, joint attention, coordinated action, collective learning). Where is the team strongest? Weakest?
12. Your team has been told to "collaborate more" with another team. Design a boundary management approach that increases inter-team information flow without destroying either team's internal coherence.
13. How does team size affect boundary management? At what point does a team become too large to maintain a coherent Markov blanket, and what structural solutions exist?
14. A startup grows from 5 people (one team) to 50 people (multiple teams). Describe the process of boundary formation as the original team differentiates into sub-teams.
15. How do cross-functional teams manage the tension between functional identity (I'm an engineer) and team identity (I'm a member of this product team)?
16. In what sense does a shared Slack channel or a shared codebase function as part of the team's Markov blanket?
17. Some organizations use "squad" models (Spotify) with matrix overlays. Analyze the boundary complexity this creates — how many Markov blankets does each person participate in?
18. How does psychological safety (Edmondson) relate to boundary management? What kind of boundary condition enables psychological safety?
19. When teams merge due to reorganization, what must happen to the separate Markov blankets? What are the typical failure modes of team merger?

20. Design a "team health dashboard" based on the coherence dimensions in this module.
What metrics would you track weekly?